

them. The project would become more secure that way.

I remember a recent incident where community members and developers teamed up for an online meeting to publicly discuss queries and concerns on Jina AI. We started this call and someone Zoom-bombed us by playing very loud music along with verbal racist abuse. This was a pretty big challenge. Thankfully, our community supported rather than blamed the organisers.

Ensuring the safety of my community members is a mindful task, but the good generally outweighs the bad.

Q How can open sourcing a project speed up its development?

A. Open sourcing does help to speed up the project. First, once you find members, you get the motivation to take the project forward faster, and that's what happened with me at Jina. There may be people who challenge you every day, and tell you that they have found some problem with the project and it's not working. So you need to build the motivation, internally and externally. But then there are those who ship their code quickly, helping the project move forward.

More importantly, collaboration works magic mysteriously. When you share the project with the world, people start using it, and then they come up with their own ideas and notions as to how it can be used and build something further out of it. They may build something that is a little different from what you built, and someone else may even make it better. And this eventually grows your project at a very exponential scale. Such growth cannot happen if you are working alone, limiting that code to a certain number of people in your team.

The best example I can share is from Jina itself. The first version took us about one year to release and the next version was released in three months. Our contributors have grown to maybe around 200 or more.



“If you are a developer, this is the time to think about open source and the ways in which you can contribute to it and be more involved in that space. Just keep learning and build projects.”

Q Do you mean to say that the number of people working on it can also impact a project's speed?

A. It is about the number of people who are engaging with the project and not necessarily only the ones contributing code to it. At the time of the Jina 1.0 release, we had 2000 stars on GitHub. This figure has reached 13,500 now. So these many people are sharing their ideas on Slack, reporting issues or helping out with other stuff that they find new.

For instance, the Jina 1.0 version puts structure to the data, creates a pipeline to operate on this data, and then eventually makes it available to the audience for search operations. The version looked very simple initially, but we figured it was complex. So we decided to break it down into three separate projects and saw an increase in its usage. The growth of Jina has been exponential in 2021.

Q How does one sustain open source projects? Any tips?

A. As a project lead, always remember you have to lead the project. Do not expect people to come and start contributing on the first day. You have to put in the effort as a leader and have to move the project forward. There will be contributions to the code or in fixing vulnerabilities, but there is no one who will give so much support that the maintainer or lead does not need to think about the project.

You can think of how to make people come in and contribute to your open source project. A couple of things have worked well for me. When you are passionate about your project and people recognise that, the chances that they will get inspired and start supporting you are very high.